

mainly intended for the academic community. Let us study some factors that differentiate Deeds from its competing tools.

User-friendly. As the target beneficiaries of this software reside primarily in the student community, the main criteria that was adopted right from the beginning was its ease of use. Most of its functions are intuitive and it is possible to use it at a basic level simply by using it without any instructions or help.

In comparison to Deeds, a professional tool is oriented towards the needs of professional users and requires skills and a proper frame of mind that beginners generally do not have. A professional tool lacks, usually, the capability to interact with learning material. So, Deeds was developed as an environment that allows interaction with tutorials, while offering quasi-professional simulation characteristics.

Blended approach. Another important element characterising Deeds

is that, pedagogical applications and Deeds functionalities have evolved together as birds of a feather. This was achieved by utilising the vast educational experience of developers.

The target of the developers is convergence of two complementary points of view—learning materials with simulation capabilities and a simulator capable of delivering learning contents.

Giuliano Donzellini envisions the next release of the software (version 2) to fully support this basic idea, allowing delivery of learning material, mainly exercises and auto-valuation tests, directly in the simulation environment.

The friend in Deed

Deeds has been used by thousands of students in Italy and other countries, from hands-on tutored laboratories to project based learning and distance education.

For a student who studies theory, Deeds is like an interactive textbook.

When the student clicks on an image, Deeds launches the corresponding simulator and opens that schematic. Therefore with the help of this software, it is possible to convey concepts at the level of complexity he or she wants.

Deeds can play the role of a teacher, too. Conventionally, when homework is given to students, it is usually some simple cases based on theory. The teacher gets the feedback from students in the form of solutions.

In Deeds system exercises, exercises are presented as HTML pages, containing text and figures of the assignments. Deeds allows students to check the correctness of solutions obtained manually and provides graphical tools for editing Web pages containing their reports, until they are satisfied with their work and use Deeds to deliver reports through the network... A friend indeed, right? ●

The author is an electronics enthusiast

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